

GRADE 7 · READING INFORMATIONAL TEXT · RI.7.5

Text Structure in Informational Text

Analyze the text structures an author uses to organize an informational text about adolescent sleep, identify signal words, and explain how each major section contributes to the whole.

Lesson Map · Passage · Guided · Partner · Independent Practice · Small Group · Answer Key

What You Will Learn Today

Learning Goals

Understand RI.7.5: Analyze the text structures an author uses to organize an informationa...

Read an original passage closely

Support every answer with text evidence

Work through guided, partner, and independent practice

How the Lesson Runs

Warm-up and passage

Guided practice together

Partner discussion

Independent + small-group work

Exit ticket and answer key

Unpacking the Standard

Authors organize informational text using structures like problem-solution, cause-effect, and compare-contrast. Signal words (such as "because," "as a result," or "in contrast") often reveal which structure is being used. Identifying structure helps you understand how ideas connect.

Modeled Example

"Screen use before bed delays melatonin release, which in turn delays sleep onset." What structure and signal words are used?

Cause-effect structure; signal phrase "in turn delays" shows one factor causing another.

"Some schools start at 7:30 a.m.; others have shifted to 8:45 a.m." What structure might this sentence introduce?

Compare-contrast structure, since it sets up two different approaches (early versus later start times) to be examined against each other.

Running on Empty

1. Sleep researchers recommend that teenagers get between eight and ten hours of sleep per night. National surveys suggest the average American teenager gets closer to seven — and often less on school nights. This gap has measurable consequences.
2. The problem begins with biology. During adolescence, the body's internal clock naturally shifts later; melatonin, the hormone that signals sleepiness, is released later in the evening than it was in childhood. As a result, many teenagers are not physically sleepy until 11 p.m. or later, regardless of what time they go to bed.
3. This biological shift collides with an unchanged school schedule. Most high schools in the study region start before 8 a.m., some as early as 7:15. Because students are not naturally sleepy until late evening, an early start time compresses their possible sleep window, sometimes to six hours or less.
4. The effects of this shortfall show up in multiple areas. Academically, researchers found students averaging under six hours of sleep scored, on average, 12 percent lower on standardized attention tasks than students averaging eight or more hours. Physically, chronic short sleep has been linked to weakened immune response and slower reaction times.
5. Some districts have tested a solution: delaying school start times. One district pushed its high

Running on Empty, continued

6. Compared to the two years before the change, average reported sleep duration increased by 34 minutes per night, tardiness dropped by 18 percent, and self-reported daytime sleepiness declined notably. Attention-task scores, by contrast, improved only slightly, suggesting some effects take longer to appear or depend on more than schedule alone.

7. Not every district has adopted later start times, largely due to logistical challenges: bus schedules, after-school sports, and working parents' schedules are all built around the earlier structure. The research is consistent, but changing an entrenched system, researchers note, is a separate challenge from proving a change would help.

Warm-up · Before You Read

1. What text structure does paragraph 1 use to introduce the topic?
2. What signal words or phrases in paragraph 2 indicate a cause-effect structure?

Guided Practice

3. What is the cause and what is the effect described in paragraph 2?

4. What signal word in paragraph 3 shows another cause-effect relationship?

Guided Practice

5. How does paragraph 3 build on the cause-effect structure introduced in paragraph 2?

6. What structure does paragraph 4 use to organize its evidence?

Partner Discussion

7. What specific evidence does paragraph 4 provide for the academic effect?

8. What structure does paragraph 5 introduce, and what signal word or phrase shows it?

Partner Discussion

9. What structure does paragraph 6 primarily use, and what is being compared?

Independent Practice

10. What signal word in paragraph 6 introduces a contrast within the results themselves?

11. Why might the author have included that contrasting detail (attention scores improving only slightly) instead of only positive results?

Independent Practice

12. What structure does paragraph 7 use to explain why more districts haven't changed their schedules?

13. How does the overall text move from problem to solution across its seven paragraphs?

Independent Practice

14. If paragraph 4 were removed, what would be lost from the text's overall structure?

15. How do paragraphs 5 and 6 work together within the compare-contrast structure?

Small-Group Work

16. Identify one additional signal word or phrase from the passage and name the structure it signals.

17. Why does the author end the passage with the challenges described in paragraph 7 rather than ending on the positive results in paragraph 6?

Small-Group Work

18. How does understanding the text's cause-effect structure in paragraphs 2–4 help a reader understand the solution presented in paragraph 5?

19. Create a one-sentence description of how this text is structured overall, using at least one structure name.

Exit Ticket

20. Explain how one major section (a specific paragraph or group of paragraphs) contributes to the development of the text's ideas as a whole.

Answer Key (1 of 4)

1. A problem structure, presenting a gap between recommended sleep (8–10 hours) and actual average sleep (about 7 hours).
2. "As a result" directly signals a cause-effect relationship between the biological shift and teens not feeling sleepy until late.
3. Cause: the body's internal clock and melatonin release shift later during adolescence. Effect: many teenagers are not physically sleepy until 11 p.m. or later.
4. "Because" signals that the early school start time (effect: compressed sleep window) is caused by students not being naturally sleepy until late evening.
5. It adds a second cause (early school start times) that combines with the first (delayed melatonin) to produce a compounded effect: a shortened sleep window.

Answer Key (2 of 4)

6. A cause-effect (or effects) structure, listing multiple effects — academic and physical — that result from the sleep shortfall.

7. Students averaging under six hours of sleep scored 12 percent lower, on average, on standardized attention tasks than students averaging eight or more hours.

8. A problem-solution structure; the phrase "tested a solution" directly signals that a proposed fix is being introduced.

9. A compare-contrast structure, comparing outcomes before and after the school start time change (sleep duration, tardiness, sleepiness, and attention scores).

10. "By contrast" signals that the attention-task results differed from the other, more positive outcomes.

Answer Key (3 of 4)

11. To present a complete, honest picture of the research, showing that not every outcome improved equally and that some effects may take longer to appear.

12. A problem structure (or cause-effect), explaining the reasons — logistical challenges like bus schedules and after-school activities — that prevent widespread adoption.

13. Paragraphs 1–4 establish the problem (the sleep gap and its causes and effects), paragraph 5 introduces a tested solution, paragraph 6 presents the solution's results, and paragraph 7 explains why the solution remains only partially adopted.

14. The text would lose its explanation of why the sleep gap matters (its academic and physical effects), weakening the case for why the solution in paragraph 5 is necessary.

15. Paragraph 5 sets up the comparison (before and after the schedule change), and paragraph 6 provides the specific data comparing outcomes across that same before-and-after divide.

Answer Key (4 of 4)

16. Examples include "compared to" (paragraph 6, compare-contrast) or "largely due to" (paragraph 7, cause-effect).

17. Ending with paragraph 7 gives a fuller, more realistic picture of the issue, showing that proving a solution works and successfully implementing it are two separate challenges.

18. Understanding the causes (biological shift, early start times) and effects (academic and physical harm) explains exactly why delaying the school start time, which targets one of the causes, was chosen as a solution.

19. Answers vary; require a structure name (problem-solution, cause-effect, or compare-contrast) and an accurate description of how it applies across the passage.

20. Answers vary; require a specific paragraph or section named, its structural role identified, and an explanation of how it connects to the text's overall development.

Exit Ticket

Answer on a sticky note

Answer the exit-ticket question from today's lesson.

Cite at least one piece of evidence from the passage.

Remember

Name your claim or answer

Quote or cite the evidence

Explain how it supports your answer